



OFF-SIDE

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RETIREMENT ISN'T A WALK IN THE PARK

It is hard for professional athletes. Their lives revolve around discipline and the pursuit of excellence. Letting go of that intensity **feels like** losing a part of yourself.

“We all came in when the sun was shining and we played through a long sunset,” Leander Paes, familiar with the trials of an extended career, told journalists at the *Sportstar/The Hindu* office while reflecting on Rafael Nadal’s first-round loss in the French Open.

“I played with Nadal in doubles at Paris Bercy [Masters]. To see a 14-time champion be unseeded and lose in the first round, I understand that feeling all too well,” the 18-time Grand Slam winner added.

Nadal, record winner of 14 Roland Garros titles, started the 2024 edition unseeded against Alexander Zverev, the fourth seed. Once the undisputed king of clay, he bowed out without much of a fight, losing in straight sets.

Though his passion for the game remains fierce, at 38, Nadal’s body, battered by more than two decades in the circuit, is no longer in sync with his indomitable spirit or his ambition — the allure of Grand Slam No. 23.

Always relentless, chasing every ball and covering every inch of the court in his prime, today’s Nadal is slower, struggling to endure the punishing rallies that once defined his game. Yet, he hasn’t given up, hasn’t made that dreaded decision to retire that every athlete fears to take.

“I don’t know if it’s gonna be the last time here in front of all of you. I’m not sure. But if it’s the last time, I enjoyed it,” he said in the post-match press conference. “I enjoy playing a lot and travelling with my family. The body is feeling better than two months ago. Maybe in two months I say it’s enough. But it’s something I don’t feel yet. I hope to be back on this court for the Olympics. That motivates me. That’s going to be another chance.”

Retirement isn’t a walk in the park. We’re all creatures

of habit, clinging to routines, and letting go of something that structured our days for so long is never simple. Without a fixed routine, we find ourselves floundering, wondering whether to start a jigsaw puzzle or pick up knitting.

It is even harder for professional athletes. Their lives revolve around discipline and the pursuit of excellence. Letting go of that intensity feels like losing a part of yourself.

Mitchell Johnson, who picked 313 wickets in 73 Test matches for Australia, spoke about his post-retirement struggles on Channel 7’s SAS Australia. “I’ve found it tougher since retiring from cricket. All of a sudden, you’re not doing as much. You sort of lose your purpose a little bit,” he admitted.

And he’s not alone. Fast bowler Shoaib Akhtar and Michael Phelps, winner of 23 Olympic golds, have all grappled with the quiet that follows the peak of their careers.

That lurking fear of the unknown often nudges athletes to hang on a bit longer, stretching their careers past their prime. Accustomed to the rhythm of training and competition and the adrenaline rush, they define their worth on the playing field. At the end of each gruelling season, burdened with fresh aches and heartbreaks, many contemplate retirement. But, yet, as the new season rolls on, most come back, perhaps each time promising it will be the last.

Mastering the perfect exit is a rare feat, like Sunil Gavaskar’s final Test knock of 96 in Bangalore or Toni Kroos bowing out after the recent Champions League victory. But for every Gavaskar, there’s a Tendulkar or a Dev, who continued even as their performances waned.

For Nadal and his fans, an Olympic gold in Roland Garros on August 4 would be the perfect farewell, the last rays of a glorious sunset.